

Just a Burning Memory

On March 10th of 2022, I crashed my 2008 Kia Spectra head-on into a logging truck at forty miles per hour. As usual, I was blasting music on my way to school, trying to make it there on time while simultaneously escaping death on the icy roads of rural Franklin County. Ironically, the last song I heard before blacking out on impact was “What was the last thing u said” by aldn. Listening to that song now transports me to the worst morning of my life. I remember the harsh, cold air as I stepped out of the totaled car, virtually unaware of what had happened. My memory of everything that led up to that moment is fuzzy, but the shred of it I can recall is forever linked to that song.

I didn’t fully realize this connection until I saw the song again in my Liked Songs list on Spotify. This list acts as a virtual timeline of my life. It’s ordered, with the most recent songs I’ve added at the top. As I scroll through I see the phases of genres and artists I’ve floated through. For example, the several months I couldn’t stop listening to Radiohead. When “Everything in Its Right Place” or “Paranoid Android” plays on shuffle it brings me back to driving my group of friends 3 hours one way to Cape Cod to cheer on our volleyball team at States. At the time I was learning music theory and how to play the piano, and had bought a signed copy of Josh Cohen’s *Radiohead for Piano*. On the long ride back from the game, most of my friends fell asleep, and I was left listening to songs from *Kid A* and *Ok Computer*, in awe of the complex music theory woven into the scores.

Some music seems to be perfectly apropos to the current chapter of your life. Yet this phenomenon of memories being attached to music applies even when it shouldn’t. An unexpected breakup a month into the pandemic sent my already fragile mental state into deep despair. I happened to be listening to Jack Stauber’s “Buttercup” the week prior and it will forever be my breakup song for that time. Jack’s oddly upbeat and unorthodox style alongside his catchy melody is the least fitting “breakup” song you’ll ever hear and yet my connection with it is eternal. Sometimes it will unexpectedly play on shuffle and send my brain spiraling down an emotional rabbit hole. “Buttercup” doesn’t just conjure heartache for me, but an entire year-long period of quarantining during the pandemic.

This pandemic is bookended in my mind by BROCKHAMPTON’s two most recent albums, *Ginger* and *Roadrunner*. Hearing them now, I vividly recall walking out to the bus while listening to *Ginger* after learning we had two weeks off from school. Those two weeks turned into four, then six, then an entire summer of waiting for the world to return to normal. 2020 felt like an eternity. But it would finally end a year later when driver’s ed reopened, and I finally got my license right before returning to in-person school. On the drive home I played *Roadrunner*, which had just come out, and I thought back to my naive self a year ago.

The correlation between music and mental imagery is inescapable and doesn’t just extend into the past, but all directions of the temporal plane. I’ll listen to a song and become nostalgic for a future I haven’t experienced yet. Unforgettable car rides with my best friends, road trips across the country, and meeting my soulmate. All of these images arise out of the indescribable qualities of the songs. Abduraqqib describes this feeling, “you climb to the

rooftops and put on headphones and let a world be built around you, a world better than whatever one you're currently in." I've noticed this phenomenon even in my grandmother who grew up in a completely different era than me, and yet still holds the same types of connections I do.

She was diagnosed with dementia 5 years ago. I had little reason to know anything about the disease until then, when it was all our family could talk about. During this time when I wanted to know more, I found an underground artist named, the Caretaker, who started to gain a cult following among video essayists online. Known only in more obscure corners of the internet and musical appreciation, the Caretaker is most famous for his project, "Everywhere at the End of Time", a six and a half hour project of looped, distorted, and slowly deteriorating 1920s ballroom music.

The work is split into 6 albums, each representing one of the stages of dementia. On a Saturday in October of 2021, I listened to the entirety of this album, starting around early afternoon. At the conclusion of the project, I sat at my desk in tears, the sunlight in my window now faded, processing the lost memories of an imaginary person I'll never know.

The Caretaker represents memories through music. The songs will loop entire sections, or skip like a broken record, like my grandma's childhood memories that constantly loop through her head. The farther you listen, the music gives way to white noise periodically interrupted by distortions or unidentifiable sounds in a section known as "Post Awareness Confusions". Other notable sections are the "Temporary Bliss State", "A confusion so thick you forget forgetting", and the introduction, "It's just a burning memory".

My grandma's connection to her past through music is paramount. She grew up as a singer, sitting on the piano as a teenager while the famous orchestrator Irwin Kostal played her a backing track. Music has always been a part of her and like many of the elderly who live with dementia, it is one of the only things left that allows a glimpse at the real her hiding underneath growing plaques in her brain. Her favorite song to sing is "It's Magic" by Doris Day.

The final stage of Everywhere at the End of Time is labeled, "Place in the World fades away," appropriately named for the essentially plain white noise it's composed of. But the last two minutes of the composition are the most important. A faint angelic chorus can be heard rising above the mental static. After a lack of discernable harmonies or melodies for two hours, it is the most beautiful thing you will ever hear. This finale is representative of a phenomenon discovered in dementia patients right before death; after forgetting even their closest family, what remains is their favorite song. One last effort by the brain to formulate a self-identity. The only connection left to their past self. Their only connection to the past at all.

Music and time are fundamentally one in the same. Aptly put, "Just a burning memory."